

Personal Knowledge Map Teacher Notes

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Knowledge and the Knower • 20-30 min

Category	Knowledge and the Knower	Time	20-30 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	personal-knowledge-map

Big idea: Knowers inherit knowledge from communities.

Overview

Students identify the communities and channels that shape what they think they know.

Student Prompt

Inspect Personal Knowledge Map Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Personal Knowledge Map Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: A knowledge map with branches for family, school, language, algorithms, memory, and experts. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Personal Knowledge Map Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: A trust colour-code showing automatic trust, earned trust, and contested trust. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Personal Knowledge Map Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A tension line between two sources that disagree about the same claim. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Knowers inherit knowledge from communities.

Actual Lesson Questions and Key

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Personal Knowledge Map Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Personal Knowledge Map Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.
6	To what extent is personal knowledge shaped by knowledge communities?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how knowers inherit knowledge from communities.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Setup Checklist

- Prepare a starter stimulus using: A knowledge map with branches for family, school, language, algorithms, memory, and experts.
- Print or project the student response grid before the activity begins.
- Plan a private first-response moment before any group discussion.

Ready-to-Use Examples

- A knowledge map with branches for family, school, language, algorithms, memory, and experts.
- A trust colour-code showing automatic trust, earned trust, and contested trust.
- A tension line between two sources that disagree about the same claim.

Suggested Timing

Stage	Teacher move	Watch for
1	Students put "my knowledge" in the centre of a page.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
2	They add branches: family, school, friends, social media, culture, language, religion, books, experts, algorithms and personal experience.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
3	They colour-code sources they trust most, least and automatically.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
4	Pairs compare one similarity and one difference.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
Debrief	Move from the activity result to a TOK knowledge question.	Students distinguishing method, evidence, interpretation, and overclaiming.

Teacher Language

- Write your first judgement before we discuss it; the first answer is useful evidence.
- Separate what you noticed from what you inferred.
- What would make this knowledge claim more reliable?

Common Misconceptions

- Students may treat perception or memory as a recording device.
- Students may assume confidence is evidence rather than a feeling about evidence.

Assessment Look-Fors

- Separates perception, memory, belief, confidence, and justification.
- Uses the activity result to make a cautious claim about knowers.

Differentiation and Adaptations

- Short lesson: use only the first example, one response grid, and one debrief question.
- Long lesson: add a second round where students revise the method and compare outcomes.
- Low-tech option: run with printed cards, sticky notes, and a board tally.

Extension Tasks

- Design a second version of the activity that tests the same knowledge issue in another AOK.
- Find a real-world example where the same knowledge problem matters outside the classroom.
- Write a 150-word TOK exhibition-style commentary using the activity as the object context.

Related Activities

- Change Blindness Starter
- Confidence Calibration Test
- Blind Spot Autobiography